***Buddhavamsa*** – A legend in verse, containing a narration of the life and activities of the 24 Buddhas who are believed to have preceded Gautama. Apart from the above canonical literature, there is a long series of non-canonical literature in Pali. They include:

- ***Milindapanha*** – which means 'questions of Milinda'. It contains a dialogue between Milinda, the Graeco-Bactrian king, and the monk Nagasena over some problems that faced Buddhism. It was originally written in Sanskrit.
- The two famous Ceylonese chronicles are ***Mahavamsa*** and ***Dipavamsa***. The former deals with the royal dynasties of the Indian subcontinent including Sri Lanka, while the latter deals with the arrival of the Buddha's teachings and preachers in Sri Lanka.
- **Buddhagosha's *Visuddhimagga*** is a later work. He is the first Buddhist commentator.
- Sanskrit literature became prominent in Buddhism with the rise of Mahayana Buddhism. However, some of the Sanskritic works were produced by the Hinayana school as well. *Buddhacharita,* written by Asvaghosa, is an epic style Sanskrit work. It tells the life history of Gautama Buddha.

## Buddhism in Tamizhakam

Buddhism is believed to have spread to the Tamil country by the Ceylonese missionaries. The evidence in support of this is some monuments of the Pandya country, which are assigned to the 3rd century B.C. (BCE). The monuments are in caverns known as Pancha Pandava Malai. Buddhism seems to have flourished and co-existed peacefully with Jainism, Ajivikam and also with various sects of Hinduism. Since the time of Bhakti Movement, Buddhism came to be challenged by its exponents and began to lose royal patronage. The *Thevaram* hymns of Saiva saints and the *Nalayira Divyaprabandam* of Vaishnava Azhwars provided evidence to the challenges Buddhism faced in Tamil country. When Hieun Tsang, the Chinese traveller, visited south India in the 7th century, Buddhism was almost on the decline.

But contrary to popular perception, the Buddhism did not disappear completely. The presence of *Virasozhiyam* (a 11th century Later Chola period grammar text, composed by a Buddhist) and the discovery of 13th century Buddhist bronzes in Nagapattinam testify to the presence of Buddhism in later periods. The sculptures of Buddha in Thiyaganur village in Salem district strengthen this conclusion.



Buddha image, Thiyaganur

Though Buddhism faced challenges from Saiva and Vaishnava sects from the Pallava period onwards. One of the exceptions was



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